

FORMULA 1

2026 SEASON

Weekend Schedules, Qualifying & Points

A Beginner's Guide to Formula 1

Standard Race Weekend

Friday to Sunday: Practice, Qualifying & Race

3

Days

5

Sessions

305 km

Race Distance

Friday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 1 (FP1)	60 minutes	Initial setup, tire evaluation, system checks
Free Practice 2 (FP2)	60 minutes	Long runs, race simulations, fine-tuning

FP1 often features rookie or reserve driver outings; teams must run a young driver in at least two FP1 sessions per season.

Saturday

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 3 (FP3)	60 minutes	Final setup, qualifying preparation
Qualifying	~60 minutes	Determines grid positions (Q1/Q2/Q3 format)

Sunday

Session	Details
Drivers' Parade	Pre-race fan engagement (track tour)
Formation Lap	Grid forms, warm-up lap to grid positions
Grand Prix Race	Full race distance (typically 305 km / ~57-70 laps)
Podium Ceremony	Top 3 celebration, trophies, national anthems

Sprint Race Weekend

Compressed Schedule with Extra Competitive Sessions

Six weekends in 2026 use the Sprint format. This replaces FP2 and FP3 with Sprint Qualifying and a short Sprint Race, adding an extra competitive session on Saturday.

Friday (Sprint)

Session	Duration	Purpose
Free Practice 1 (FP1)	60 minutes	Only practice session of the weekend
Sprint Qualifying (SQ)	~36 minutes	SQ1/SQ2/SQ3 to set Sprint grid

Saturday (Sprint)

Session	Duration	Purpose
Sprint Race	~30 min (100 km)	Short race, separate points awarded
Qualifying	~60 minutes	Sets grid for Sunday's Grand Prix

Sprint Weekend Note

Parc ferme conditions apply from the start of Sprint Qualifying. Teams must balance setup for both the Sprint and the Grand Prix with very limited practice data from just one FP session.

Qualifying Format

Q1 / Q2 / Q3 Knockout System

Qualifying uses a three-part knockout format to determine the starting grid for the Grand Prix.

Phase	Duration	Drivers	Eliminated	Grid Positions
Q1	18 minutes	All 22	Slowest 5	P18 - P22
Q2	15 minutes	Remaining 17	Slowest 5	P13 - P17
Q3	12 minutes	Top 12	None (ranked)	P1 - P12

107% Rule

Any driver who fails to set a Q1 time within 107% of the fastest Q1 lap may not be permitted to start the race, at the stewards' discretion.

Sprint Qualifying (SQ1 / SQ2 / SQ3)

Phase	Duration	Eliminated
SQ1	12 minutes	Slowest 5
SQ2	10 minutes	Slowest 5
SQ3	8 minutes	None (top 12 ranked)

Race Day Procedures

Pre-Race: Pit lane opens 30 minutes before race start. Cars take positions on the grid. All cars must be on the grid 10 minutes before the start. Tire blankets removed, teams clear the grid.

Race Start: Formation lap behind the pole-sitter to warm tires and brakes. Cars return to grid positions for a standing start. Five red lights illuminate sequentially, then all extinguish simultaneously to signal the start.

Lights Out!

The race start is one of F1's most thrilling moments. Five red lights come on one by one (about 1 second apart), then all go out at once. Drivers must react instantly. The best reaction times are under 0.2 seconds. A jump start (moving before lights out) results in a penalty.

During the Race: At least one pit stop is mandatory (must use at least two different dry tire compounds). Active aero (X-mode) replaces DRS on designated straights. Blue flags require lapped cars to let leaders through within 3 flag points. Track limits violations lead to lap time deletion or time penalties.

Points System

Grand Prix Points (Top 10)

Pos	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th	9th	10th
Pts	25	18	15	12	10	8	6	4	2	1

+1 point for the fastest lap, provided the driver finishes in the top 10.

Sprint Points (Top 8)

Pos	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th
Pts	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1

No fastest lap point is awarded in Sprint races.

26

Max Pts (Standard)

34

Max Pts (Sprint)

25

Race Win

8

Sprint Win